

Digital Menschen

The Ten Commandments of Ethical Online Behavior

Rooted in Jewish Values • Informed by Youth Voices • Calibrated for the AI Era

A guide for Jewish communities, camps, youth groups,
schools, and families navigating the digital age
with wisdom, compassion, and intention.

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Introduction

Jewish tradition has always understood that how we speak to and about one another is a sacred act. The laws of *lashon hara* (harmful speech), the ethics of *derech eretz* (basic decency), and the vision of *tikkun olam* (repairing the world) were articulated long before the internet existed, yet they speak directly to the challenges of digital life.

Today's teens are growing up in a world where nearly half of them are online almost constantly (Pew Research, 2024). They navigate complex social dynamics across platforms, face cyberbullying and misinformation, and struggle with the mental health effects of curated digital lives. And now, a powerful new dimension has emerged: 64% of U.S. teens have used AI chatbots, with nearly a third using them daily (Pew Research, 2025). AI companions, AI-assisted schoolwork, AI-generated images and text: these are no longer futuristic concerns. They are the daily reality of the young people in our care.

These Ten Commandments of Ethical Online Behavior draw on the deep wells of Jewish wisdom to offer a moral framework for digital life in the age of social media and artificial intelligence. Rather than treating AI as a separate topic, these commandments look for the places where AI raises an old question in a new form, and name it there. That is a judgment call, and it is one the first readers of this document pushed back on. Teenagers at two pilot camps told us plainly that in several commandments the technology felt bolted on, and that much of their digital life has nothing to do with AI at all. They were right, and this version reflects it: AI appears where it genuinely belongs, and the rest is written about people, whatever tool is in their hands. The questions AI raises about honesty, dignity, effort, stewardship, and connection are not new questions. They are ancient questions in new clothing.

The commandments are arranged in four groups that move from the personal to the communal. The first four address how we see and treat other people, from recognizing the Divine image in every person to actively choosing kindness. The fifth and sixth address how we navigate information and privacy in an age of AI. The seventh and eighth turn inward, exploring the value of genuine effort in learning and the practice of sacred rest. The final two look outward to the wider world, calling us to pursue justice for those who are left behind and to take responsibility for the impact our digital choices have on the planet.

Each commandment is grounded in a specific Jewish value and informed by current research on what teens experience, want, and hope for in their online interactions. They are intended to inspire conversation, not to prescribe rigid rules. They are meant to open doors to reflection and growth for people of all ages.

Derech eretz kadma l'Torah: Basic human decency precedes even Torah itself.
(Vayikra Rabbah 9:3)

The Ten Commandments of Ethical Online Behavior

I. Recognize the Divine in Every Person You Encounter Online

Jewish Value: *B'tzelem Elohim - Created in the Divine Image* - בְּצֶלֶם אֱלֹהִים

The Torah teaches, “And God created the human in the Divine image” (Genesis 1:27). Behind every screen name, profile picture, and comment is a human being who carries that image. That means the person on the other end of your screen carries infinite worth and dignity, even when you disagree with them, even when you can't see their face, and even if it's easier to dismiss them as bots or AI. *B'tzelem Elohim* asks us to look for the Divine in every person we encounter online, and to let that recognition shape how we type, share, and respond. This is hardest when the person is a stranger, an account with no face, or someone you will never meet. Distance makes dismissal easy, and a screen is a lot of distance. Whatever sits between you, a real person is affected by what you post about them, and holding onto that is an act of sacred attention. The reverse is also true and worth saying out loud: the same screens that make dismissal easy put you in the room with people you would never otherwise meet, three time zones away, who share your rare condition, your obscure passion, or your questions about God. Recognizing the Divine online is not only a restraint on what you do. It is an opportunity no previous generation had at this scale. What would change about your next comment, post, or share if you truly saw the person on the other end as someone created in the image of God?

What Teens Are Saying: *48% of teens now say social media has a negative impact on people their age (Pew, 2024). Teens want to feel seen as whole human beings online, not reduced to likes, followers, or a single post. Push back: the same surveys find that many teens describe online spaces as where they finally found people who understand them. “Harmful” and “essential” are both true, often about the same platform and the same person.*

II. Guard Your Tongue: Whether You Type the Words or AI Does

Jewish Value: *Shmirat HaLashon - Guarding One's Speech* - שְׁמִירַת הַלָּשׁוֹן

The Book of Proverbs warns, “Death and life are in the power of the tongue” (Proverbs 18:21). Jewish tradition teaches that harmful speech, *lashon hara*, can wound as deeply as any weapon. Online, words travel faster, reach further, and last forever. Do not gossip,

shame, mock, or spread rumors, even when you think no one will trace it back to you. *Shmirat halashon* extends to AI-assisted communication: if you use a chatbot to draft a message, generate a caption, or write a comment, you are still responsible for every word. An algorithm cannot absolve you of *lashon hara* – toxic speech. Read what AI writes for you with the same moral care you would give your own words. The reach that makes a rumor dangerous makes a decent word travel just as far. A public defense of someone who is being piled on reaches everyone who watched the pile-on, and is remembered longer.

Before you hit send, ask: would I say this to someone's face, and does it matter who wrote the words?

What Teens Are Saying: 46% of U.S. teens have experienced at least one form of cyberbullying, with offensive name-calling being the most common (Pew, 2022). More than half say cyberbullying is a major problem for people their age (Pew, 2024). Teens are clear: harmful words online cause real harm, whether those words come from humans or are generated by AI tools. Push back: a participant in one of our pilots argued that many rules like this one amount to over-censorship, and that the answer to bad speech is more speech rather than less. Where is that line for you, and who gets to draw it?

III. Honor and Protect the Dignity of Every Person

Jewish Value: *K'vod HaAdam* - Human Dignity - כבוד הָאָדָם

Do not humiliate anyone publicly. The Talmud teaches that publicly shaming another person is akin to shedding blood (Talmud Bava Metzia 58b). Never share someone else's private images, messages, or personal information without their consent. Do not participate in pile-ons, and do not stand silently while someone is being attacked online. Be an upstander, not a bystander. *K'vod HaAdam* also means refusing to use any tool to degrade another person: a fabricated screenshot, an anonymous account made to harass, a face-swap app, an image generator. New tools do not invent cruelty. They lower the effort it takes, and effort was the only thing that used to slow it down. The same platforms make it unusually easy to do the opposite. Standing up for someone online costs you a sentence, not a physical stand in a hallway, and everyone watching sees that somebody said so.

If you saw someone being attacked online right now, what would it take for you to step in?

What Teens Are Saying: Cyberbullying continues to rise among U.S. youth (Cyberbullying Research Center, 2023). Harassment now includes convincing fake images made with face-swap and image-generation apps that take minutes and require no skill. Teens want allies who will speak up, not just "not participate." They want communities that actively protect members. Push back: "be an upstander" is cheap to say and expensive to do. What actually happens to the person who steps in? Any honest conversation about this commandment has to include that cost.

IV. Practice Derech Eretz and Choose Chesed: Be Decent, Be Kind, Be a Mensch

Jewish Values: *Derech Eretz - The Way of Common Decency - דרך ערץ*

Chesed - Loving-Kindness - חסד

The Sages teach that *derech eretz*, basic decency and respect, comes before Torah itself (Vayikra Rabbah 9:3). Online spaces are real social spaces with real consequences. Be courteous. When you disagree, do so respectfully. Welcome newcomers. Use the same manners you would use face to face. But *derech eretz* is only the beginning. Jewish tradition also calls us to *chesed*, active loving-kindness. The world is sustained by three things: Torah, worship, and acts of loving-kindness (Pirkei Avot 1:2). Don't just avoid causing harm; be the person who encourages others, celebrates their successes, and offers support when someone is struggling. A kind comment can change someone's entire day. In a world where AI can generate endless content, the most valuable thing you can offer is something no algorithm can produce: genuine human warmth and care. Choose to be the real voice in someone's feed that makes them feel less alone.

What is one way you could bring genuine chesed into someone's digital experience today?

What Teens Are Saying: *Studies show that teens identify "misunderstanding and conflict from communication that is not face-to-face" as a significant challenge (Montana State, 2024). And fewer teens credit social media as a genuine support system, down to 52% from 67% in 2022 (Pew, 2024). Teens want online spaces that feel both respectful and authentically warm, not just free of cruelty, but full of real connection.*

V. Seek Truth: Do Not Spread Falsehood, Do Not Steal What Others Have Created

Jewish Values: *Emet - Truth - אמת*

Geneivat Da'at - Theft of Mind - גניבת דעת

The Torah commands: "Distance yourself from falsehood" (Exodus 23:7). In an era of misinformation and deepfakes, this commandment is more urgent than ever. Verify before you share. Question what you see. Be honest in your own posts. Do not present a false version of yourself or others. Jewish tradition also prohibits *geneivat da'at*, literally "theft of the mind," which means deceiving others about the true nature of something. When AI generates text, art, or music, that output is built on the creative work of real human beings whose writing, art, and ideas were used to train it, often without their permission or compensation. Present AI-generated work honestly. Do not claim it as your own creation, and recognize that behind every AI output are the uncredited contributions of real artists, writers, and thinkers. Campers in one of our pilot sessions said it more plainly than this document had: if you did not make it, say what it is, and list your source if the source is not

you. A source that is not listed is assumed to be you. This applies to a human being's work exactly as much as it applies to a machine's. Used honestly, these tools are remarkable for truth-seeking. You can check a claim in seconds, read the primary source instead of somebody's summary of it, and hear directly from people who were actually there. A tool that condenses ten sources is a gift to a person who knows how to verify it and a trap for a person who does not. Learn to be the first kind.

The next time you encounter content online, ask yourself: is this true, who made it, and is that transparent?

What Teens Are Saying: *30% of young Americans now get their news from social media (Edutopia, 2024). The share of teens using ChatGPT for schoolwork doubled from 13% to 26% in a single year (Pew, 2025). Many teens are finding real value in AI as a study tool, but they're also navigating harder questions about originality, credit, and intellectual property that most adults haven't figured out yet either. Push back: teens draw finer lines here than adults usually credit. Checking your own reasoning against a tool is not the same act as having it think for you, and treating those as one thing is the fastest way to lose a room of teenagers.*

VI. Protect Privacy: What You Share Lives On

Jewish Value: *Tzniut - Modesty and Discretion - צניעות*

Judaism values modesty and discretion not as restriction but as protection of human dignity. Guard your personal boundaries online. Think carefully before sharing private information, images, or conversations. Once something is shared digitally, you lose control of it. Be aware that your data is valuable: the apps and platforms you use collect, store, and often sell information about you, from your browsing habits to your location. Be especially thoughtful about what you share with AI systems. Personal details, photos, and intimate conversations entered into AI chatbots may be stored, analyzed, and used to train future models in ways you cannot foresee or control. *Tzniut* reminds us that not everything needs to be public to be real. Privacy also includes the right to refuse: to decline the terms, to opt out of the collection, to say no when a form asks for your face, your age, or your address because asking is easy and refusing is made hard. Consent you cannot withhold is not consent. Privacy is not the same as absence. The goal is not to disappear; it is to take part fully while keeping what is yours. The prophet Micah calls us “to walk modestly with your God” (Micah 6:8).

Before you share something online or enter it into an AI chatbot, ask: does this need to be shared, and do I know where it goes next?

What Teens Are Saying: 74% of teens believe AI platforms should discourage the sharing of personal information (Common Sense Media, 2025). Yet about a quarter of teen AI companion users have shared personal details with these platforms, often without understanding how that data may be stored, sold, or used to train future models (Common Sense Media, 2025). Teens get that privacy matters. The gap is between what they value and what the platforms make easy. Push back: a participant in one of our pilots pointed out that rules like this put the weight on individuals for choices that companies made. Personal discretion is real, but so is the fact that the terms were written to be accepted.

VII. Take Responsibility: True Learning Comes from the Wrestling

Jewish Value: *Arevut - Responsibility* - עֲרֵבוּת

Yegi'ah - The Toil of Learning - יְגִיעָה

Jewish tradition teaches that "all Israel are responsible for one another." *Arevut* means that what we do and what we create matters beyond ourselves. In the digital age, this means taking ownership of what you post, share, and amplify. Your digital footprint is part of your character. Build it with integrity. The real test of *arevut* is what you do when your name is not attached to it. An anonymous account, a burner, a second profile made so that nothing traces back to you: the words are still yours, and so is the harm they do. Responsibility is what you practice when nobody could prove it was you. *Arevut* also calls us to honesty about how we learn. Torah is acquired not through shortcuts but through human teachers, careful discussion with chevrotah partners, and the hard work of wrestling with ideas you don't yet understand (Pirkei Avot 6:6). Jewish learning has always been built on *yegi'ah*: the struggle itself is where growth happens. AI can hand you a polished answer in seconds, but it cannot give you the experience of sitting with a difficult text or topic, arguing it out with a partner, and arriving at understanding you earned. There is a difference between using a tool to support your learning and using a tool to skip it. When you present something to the world, whether an essay, a *d'var Torah*, or a project, let it reflect your real mind and your real effort. None of this means the tools are the enemy. AI is a genuinely good study partner: it will explain the same concept a fifth time without sighing, at two in the morning, to a student whose school cannot provide a tutor. That is real, and it is exactly why the distinction matters between a tool that helps you walk and a tool that skips the walk.

The next time AI offers you a quick answer, ask: what would I learn by wrestling with this myself?

What Teens Are Saying: Teens themselves draw lines around AI in learning: 54% say using ChatGPT for research is acceptable, but only 18% say the same for writing essays (Pew, 2025). 71% of Gen Z who encounter online risks now report seeking help or speaking to someone (Snap Digital Well-Being Index, 2025). Teens want a culture where accountability is expected, effort is valued, and asking for help is a sign of strength, not a shortcut. Push back: adults calling AI a shortcut

often mean essay writing, while teens mean explanation, translation, and getting unstuck. Naming which one you are talking about is the difference between a conversation and a lecture.

VIII. Observe Digital Shabbat: Create Sacred Boundaries with Technology

Jewish Value: *Shabbat - Sacred Rest and Boundaries - שבת*

On the seventh day, God finished the work of creation and rested (Genesis 2:2). Just as Shabbat teaches us to rest from creation, practice stepping away from your screens: from social media, from AI chatbots, from the endless scroll. Set intentional boundaries around your device use. You are more than your online presence. Shabbat is the scheduled version of something you can practice at any hour: being where you actually are. A phone in your hand during a conversation tells the person in front of you exactly where they rank. Turning it face down is a small act of kavod, and it costs you nothing. You do not have to disappear for twenty-five hours to begin. Begin with dinner. AI companions are designed to be always available, always agreeable, and always engaging, which can make disconnection feel harder, but also makes it more necessary. At the same time, not everyone has equal access to the human support they need: a therapist, a rabbi, a mentor, or even consistent internet. For some, AI tools can be a meaningful bridge, and online communities can offer real connection. *Shabbat* doesn't ask us to reject the tools we rely on; it asks us to be intentional about when we use them, when we rest from them, and when we turn toward the people and relationships that sustain us.

What would it look like for you to practice a digital Shabbat, even for an hour?

What Teens Are Saying: *44% of teens report trying to cut back on social media or smartphone use (Pew, 2024). 64% of teens have used AI chatbots, with 28% using them daily (Pew, 2025). 72% of teens have tried AI companions, with a third saying talking to AI feels as good as or better than talking to a real friend (Common Sense Media, 2025). Teens recognize the need for balance and are actively seeking permission and support to disconnect. Push back: for some teens an always-available chatbot is the only thing available at three in the morning. Telling them to disconnect, without asking what they are disconnecting from, misses the point.*

IX. Pursue Digital Justice: Build a World That Leaves No One Behind

Jewish Value: *Tzedek - Justice and Righteousness - צדק*

"Justice, justice shall you pursue" (Deuteronomy 16:20). *Tzedek* demands that we look beyond our own experience and ask: who is missing? Not everyone has consistent access to the internet, a working device, or the subscriptions that unlock the tools others take for

granted. When we assume everyone is equally connected, we leave people out. When we build Jewish spaces online without thinking about accessibility, we close doors that should be open. *Tzedek* in the digital age means designing and choosing platforms that work for people with visual or hearing impairments, creating content that doesn't assume a single way of learning, and remembering that a community is only as strong as its commitment to including every member. AI tools hold real promise for bridging some of these gaps: translating languages, generating captions, supporting different learning styles. But only if access to those tools is itself just and equitable.

Before you build, post, or share, ask: who is this leaving out, and what can I do about it?

What Teens Are Saying: *The gap between teens from high-income families and those from low-income families in AI use reached 24 percentage points in 2025, double the gap observed in 2024 (CARE/USC, 2025). Teens in lower- and middle-income households are also less likely to have access to a home computer or tablet (Pew, 2024). The digital divide isn't just about who's online. It's about who has the tools to learn, create, and participate fully. Justice means making sure the answer isn't determined by your zip code or your family's income.*

X. Use Your Online Presence to Repair the World

Jewish Values: *Tikkun Olam - Repairing the World - תיקון עולם*
Bal Tashchit - Do Not Destroy - בל תשחית

Every post, share, and comment is an opportunity for *tikkun*, repair. Use your platform to uplift, educate, advocate, and create. Share content that builds up rather than tears down. The digital world is not separate from the real world; what you do online shapes the world we all share. Be aware, too, that our digital choices have a physical cost. AI systems consume enormous amounts of energy and water. Every query, every generated image, every chatbot conversation draws on real resources from the real earth. The Jewish principle of *bal tashchit* (do not waste or destroy) calls us to use these powerful tools mindfully, not frivolously.

Ask yourself: is this use of technology truly serving *tikkun*, or is it just convenience at the world's expense?

What Teens Are Saying: *Despite concerns, many teens still say social media helps them find creative inspiration and access helpful information (Pew, 2024). Teens increasingly care about environmental responsibility and want to understand the real-world footprint of their digital habits. Push back: individual restraint barely moves the environmental number. Industry practice and public policy do. That does not make personal choices meaningless, but it does mean this commandment is about who you are becoming as much as it is about kilowatts.*

A Final Word

The digital world is not a separate world. It is our world, an extension of our homes, our communities, our relationships. Jewish tradition teaches that every moment is an opportunity for holiness, and every encounter with another person is an encounter with the Divine. These commandments are an invitation to bring that awareness into every keystroke, every comment, every share, and every interaction with AI.

Artificial intelligence will continue to grow more powerful and more present in our lives. But technology, however sophisticated, cannot replace what makes us most human: our capacity for genuine empathy, moral reasoning, and sacred relationship. The question is not whether our teens will use these tools, but what kind of people they will be when they do.

As the Talmud reminds us: "Whoever preserves a single soul, it is as though they have preserved an entire world" (Sanhedrin 37a). In the digital age, the ways we treat one another online ripple outward in ways we may never fully see. Let us choose, in every interaction, to build a world worthy of the one God imagined.

"In a place where there are no human beings, strive to be a human being."

Pirkei Avot 2:5

An Important Note

This document was developed with the assistance of AI tools for research, drafting, and revision, modeling the kind of transparent, human-guided AI use these commandments advocate.

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- Talmud: Sanhedrin 37a (preserving a single soul); Bava Metzia 58b (public shaming); Berakhot 17a (speech and character); Chullin 94a (geneivat da'at / deception)
- Mishnah: Pirkei Avot 1:2 (three pillars); Pirkei Avot 2:5 (being human); Pirkei Avot 6:6 (Torah acquired through effort and community)
- Vayikra Rabbah 9:3 ("Derech eretz kadma l'Torah")
- Deuteronomy 16:20 (tzedek); Deuteronomy 20:19–20 (bal tashchit: prohibition against needless destruction)
- Proverbs 18:21 (power of the tongue) Micah 6:8 (walking modestly with God) Chofetz Chaim: Shmirat HaLashon (laws of ethical speech)
- Rambam (Maimonides): Hilchot De'ot (Laws of Character Traits); Hilchot Geneivah (Laws of Theft, including geneivat da'at)